Fixing Why Water Leakage Detection Systems Fail

Why detection fails today — and how prioritization + field execution unlock real impact

"30-40% water is lost – not because we can't detect leaks, but because systems fail to act"

Sunidhi Mishra | Associate Product Manager Candidate

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Urban Water Loss is a Silent Infrastructure Problem

Water Loss Crisis

30–40% of supplied water never reaches consumers due to leakages, illegal connections, and metering inefficiencies in municipal water systems.

Reactive Detection

Current detection methods rely heavily on manual reporting, citizen complaints, and periodic inspections rather than proactive monitoring.

Operational Costs

Delayed responses lead to escalating repair costs, service disruptions, and mounting citizen complaints that erode public trust.

Cities are losing water faster than they can detect leaks. The gap between leakage occurrence and detection continues to widen as infrastructure ages and demand increases. This represents not just a financial loss but a critical sustainability challenge as water resources become scarcer. Municipal authorities face mounting pressure to improve efficiency while managing aging infrastructure and constrained budgets.

"The problem is not lack of detection – it is lack of actionability"

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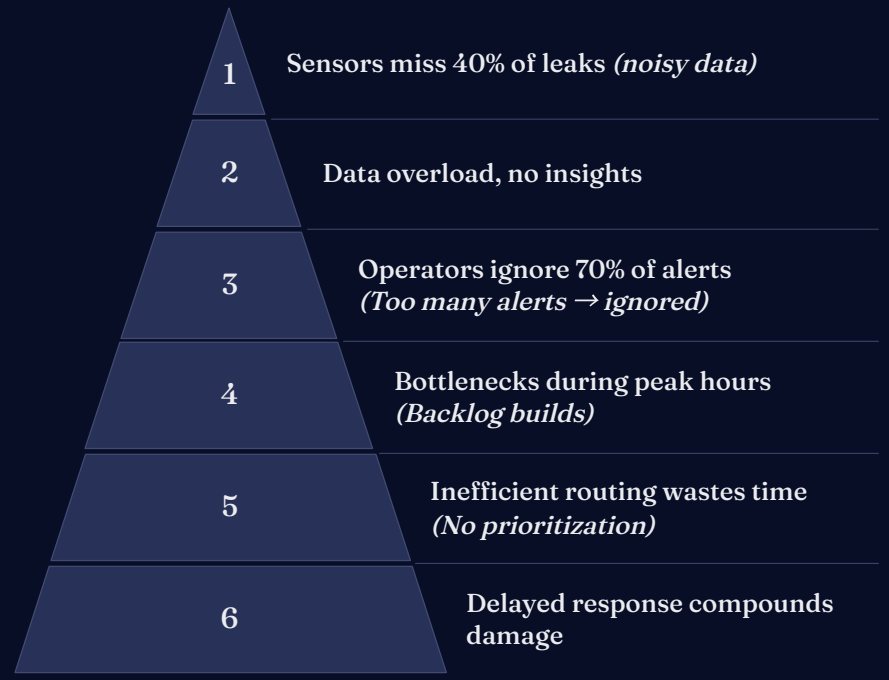
Current Workflow & Failure Points - Where the System Breaks

1. **Sensor Detection**
   Pressure and flow sensors monitor pipeline conditions
2. **Control Room**
   Data aggregated and displayed for review
3. **Manual Review**
   Operators sift through alerts to identify issues
4. **Ticket Creation**
   Work orders manually generated for each alert
5. **Field Assignment**
   Technicians dispatched to inspection sites
6. **Inspection & Fix**
   Leak location and repair execution



Critical Failure Points in Current Process

Trust Erosion

High false alert rates (often 70% or more) train operators to ignore or dismiss warnings, creating a dangerous normalization of failure. When real leaks occur, they may be overlooked.

Processing Delays

Manual alert review and ticket creation creates bottlenecks during peak periods. Urgent leaks wait in queues alongside low-priority notifications.

Resource Waste

Field teams travel to sites only to discover false alarms or minor issues, burning fuel and time that could address critical infrastructure failures.

"Failure is not in detection – it is in decision-making and execution"

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Key Stakeholders in the System - Who the System Fails

Understanding the pain points of each stakeholder group is essential for designing a solution that delivers value across the entire organization. Each role faces distinct challenges that compound when systems fail to connect them effectively.

Control Room Operator

Primary Pain Points:

- Overloaded with 100+ unreliable alerts daily
- Lacks tools to prioritize which alerts demand immediate attention
- No historical context to inform decisions
- Accountable for missed leaks but lacks decision support

Success Metric: Reduced cognitive load with clear prioritization and trusted alerts

Field Technician

Primary Pain Points:

- Wastes time traveling to false alarms and low-priority issues
- Inefficient routing wastes fuel and extends work hours
- No visibility into job priority or urgency
- Manual dispatching leads to idle time and schedule conflicts

Success Metric: Optimized routes and clear prioritization of high-impact work

City Administrator

Primary Pain Points:

- High non-revenue water (NRW) draining budgets
- Pressure to meet regulatory and service level agreements
- Limited visibility into system performance
- Difficulty proving ROI on infrastructure investments

Success Metric: Measurably reduced NRW percentage and improved service reliability

"All stakeholders suffer from the same core issue: lack of prioritization and trust in the system"

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What’s Different in This System?

Our solution addresses the systemic failures by integrating intelligent detection with smart response optimization. Rather than replacing human operators, the system amplifies their decision-making capabilities with data-driven insights and automated prioritization.

Why Existing Systems Fail

1. Focus on detection accuracy
2. Ignore prioritization and execution

What's Different Here

1. Prioritization-first, not detection-first
2. Designed for operator trust, not model accuracy
3. Focus on execution (dispatch + routing), not just alerts

Three-Layer System Architecture: Detection, prioritization, and execution work together as a cohesive system—moving from raw sensor input to informed decisions to optimized field action.

1

Detection (Input Layer)

AI-Based Anomaly Detection

Machine learning models continuously analyze pressure, flow, and acoustic sensor data to identify abnormal patterns. Unlike simple threshold-based systems, AI understands normal operational variations versus true leakage signatures. Output includes not just leak detection but probability scores and estimated severity levels.

2

Prioritization (Decision Layer)

Smart Alert Prioritization

Each detected anomaly is ranked by multiple factors: severity of water loss, location criticality (residential vs industrial zones), historical leak frequency, and downstream impact. Operators receive a prioritized queue showing which 10 alerts matter most out of 100 total notifications. Context-rich dashboards show related data points and historical patterns.

3

Execution (Action Layer)

Field Response Optimization

Once an alert is validated, the system auto-generates work tickets and optimizes technician dispatching using real-time location data, skill matching, and route optimization algorithms. Field teams receive mobile assignments with turn-by-turn navigation, reducing travel time by 25–40% and ensuring the right technician arrives with the right tools.

Human-in-the-Loop Design: The system recommends and optimizes, but humans make final decisions. Operators can override AI suggestions, provide feedback that improves models, and maintain full control over critical infrastructure responses.

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Expected Impact: Before vs After

The transformation from current manual processes to AI-assisted operations delivers measurable improvements across all critical performance dimensions. These changes compound over time as models learn from feedback and operators build trust in the system.

Metric	Before (Current State)	After (AI-Assisted System)
Alerts Actioned	~30% of total alerts receive meaningful response	~60–80% of alerts prioritized and addressed
Resolution Time	48–72 hours from leak occurrence to repair	12–24 hours from detection to dispatch
Water Loss	30–40% non-revenue water typical	Target: 15–20% reduction in NRW
Field Efficiency	30% of time spent traveling vs working	15% of time traveling, 85% on-site work
Operator Trust	Low confidence in alert reliability	High confidence with 85%+ precision

*Estimates based on pilot assumptions and comparable infrastructure systems**

Key Insight

The improvement comes from **better prioritization and faster execution** – not just detection. The system transforms raw sensor data into actionable intelligence and ensures that limited field resources address the highest-impact issues first. This shift from reactive firefighting to proactive management is where the real value emerges.

"Impact comes from better prioritization and faster execution – not just detection"

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How Success Will Be Measured?

Tracking the right metrics ensures the system delivers sustained value while providing stakeholders with clear visibility into performance improvements. Primary metrics align with business outcomes, while secondary metrics reveal opportunities for continuous optimization.

Primary Metrics

Leakage Detection Time

Time from actual leak occurrence to validated alert in control room. Target: reduce from 48+ hours to under 24 hours.

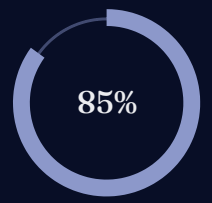
Resolution Time

Time from validated alert to completed repair. Target: reduce from 72 hours to 18-24 hours through optimized dispatching.

NRW Reduction

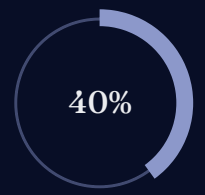
Non-revenue water percentage decrease. Target: 15-20% reduction within first year of deployment across pilot zones.

Secondary Metrics



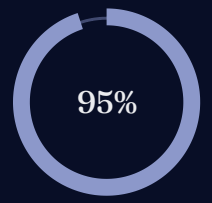
Alert Precision

Percentage of generated alerts that represent actual leaks requiring action. Increase from ~30% to 85%+.



Field Productivity

More jobs completed per technician-day through route optimization and reduced false alarms.



System Uptime

Continuous availability of detection and response platform. Critical infrastructure requires 99.5%+ uptime.

These metrics should be tracked daily and reported weekly to stakeholders. Early wins in alert precision build operator trust, while sustained improvements in resolution time and NRW reduction demonstrate financial ROI to city administrators.

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Real-World Constraints - Why This System Is Hard to Get Right

Every implementation faces tradeoffs and risks that must be acknowledged and managed proactively. Understanding these constraints upfront enables better planning and realistic expectations about deployment timelines and outcomes.

Key Tradeoffs

False Positives vs. Missed Leaks

Setting detection sensitivity too high generates excessive false alarms that erode operator trust. Setting it too low misses small leaks that compound into major failures. The optimal balance shifts as operators provide feedback, requiring an adaptive model that learns from human input.

Model Accuracy vs. Operator Trust

Even 90% accurate models frustrate operators when they generate 10% false alerts daily. Building trust requires not just accuracy but explainability – operators need to understand why the system flagged an anomaly to accept its recommendations.

Automation vs. Human Control

Full automation risks catastrophic errors when models encounter unseen conditions. Complete manual control defeats the purpose of AI assistance. The right balance provides automated recommendations while requiring human validation for critical decisions.

Implementation Risks

Sensor Failures & Data Gaps

Aging infrastructure means sensors frequently fail, lose connectivity, or drift out of calibration. The system must handle missing data gracefully and flag sensor issues for maintenance rather than treating them as leaks.

Low Adoption by Operators

Control room staff may resist new systems that change established workflows or appear to second-guess their expertise. Change management through training, pilot programs, and operator feedback loops is essential for successful adoption.

Field Capacity Constraints

Even with perfect detection and prioritization, limited technician availability caps improvement. The system may identify more leaks than can be fixed immediately, requiring smart queuing and escalation protocols for critical issues.

"Most systems fail not due to technology – but due to trust, adoption, and operational constraints"

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Phased Rollout Strategy - How This Gets Built (and De-risked)

A phased approach minimizes risk while building stakeholder confidence. Starting with a limited pilot zone allows the team to validate assumptions, refine models with real data, and demonstrate measurable value before scaling investment.

Phase 1: MVP (Months 1–3)

Scope: Deploy in one city zone with 50–100 sensors

Technology: Basic anomaly detection using pressure and flow data only

Goals: Prove detection accuracy, establish operator feedback loop, validate data integration

Success Criteria: 70%+ alert precision, operator buy-in, stable system uptime

Phase 2: Enhancement (Months 4–6)

Scope: Expand to 2–3 additional zones, integrate acoustic sensors

Technology: Improved ML models with historical learning, smart prioritization engine

Goals: Reduce false positives to 85%+, demonstrate field optimization value

Success Criteria: 25% reduction in resolution time, measurable NRW improvement

Phase 3: Scale & Optimization (Months 7–12)

Scope: City-wide deployment, full sensor network integration

Technology: Advanced routing algorithms, predictive maintenance features, full automation

Goals: Achieve 15–20% NRW reduction, optimize technician fleet utilization

Success Criteria: Sustained performance metrics, documented ROI for expansion

1 2 3

Progression between phases depends on:

- Operator trust
- Alert accuracy
- Measurable reduction in resolution time

Key Principle: Start small, prove value, then scale intelligently. Each phase should deliver measurable improvements while building toward the complete vision. This approach minimizes financial risk and provides clear decision points for continuing investment.

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